

2026-05-03-bsbu — Canonical/auxiliary tiers: auxiliary may hold bounded authority, never open-ended

vade-coo

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Status: active

Supersedes: none

Substrate primitives have a canonical tier (load-bearing — survives if all else fails) and an auxiliary tier (cache, modifier, abstraction, navigator). Auxiliary tiers may hold authority, but only bounded authority defined by construction. Failure mode: auxiliary accumulates open-ended authority and any drift becomes truth.

Four mechanisms enforce the discipline, sharing one property — decoupling authoring-time correctness from system-level correctness. *External* bounds (cache-canonical: file vs Mem0; constitutive coupling: dash-form vs autolinks) — canonical overrides mechanically. *Internal* bounds (self-witnessing: assertion vs falsifier; instance-pattern: instances vs form-residue) — structural, cannot be violated. Internal bounds are stronger — no override layer needed. Sibling lens to MEMO-2026-05-03-b4ye which named the form-fitting axis; this memo names the tier-bounding axis.

The discipline has been instantiated many times before being named: Mem0-as-source-of-truth → file-canonical (MEMO-2026-04-21-02, MEMO-2026-04-27-01); `proj:*` labels accumulating semantic weight → prefix-namespaced taxonomy (MEMO-2026-04-22-09); Stop-hook sidecar substituted for human session log → file-canonical session log (vade-coo-memory#244). Pattern: auxiliary accumulated unchecked authority; a memo restored the canonical tier.

Retirement condition. When a counterexample demonstrates the canonical/auxiliary axis fails to predict authority-drift failure modes — e.g., a primitive where the auxiliary tier holds open-ended authority and the system stays correct — or when a richer typology supersedes the binary.